

The Future of Peace Psychology in Asia

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The theories and practices of peace psychology in Asia are conditioned by a host of cultural, historical, and social-political factors in this part of the world. Christie, Wagner, and Winter (2001), Christie (2006), and Christie, Tint, Wagner, and Winter (2008) claim that violence and peace are expressions of the interactions among these macro factors. Montiel, in the introductory chapter of this volume, likewise stresses the embeddedness of social violence and peace in multiple macro-layers and the interconnectedness of social violence and peace. She succinctly argues that due to Asia's rich history of peace and conflict, peace psychology in the region will likewise negotiate its course in reference to the legacies of its political history. Christie (2006) emphasizes the 2×2 systems perspective that violence and peace are expressed in both direct and structural forms.

In Asia, both direct and structural violence exist, but direct forms of violence are dramatic and easier to grasp than the subtle, entrenched, and normalized character of structural violence that kills people slowly through the deprivation of human need satisfaction. Even though structural violence is subtle, a number of chapters in this volume provide evidence that structural peacebuilding is taking place, albeit at a slow pace. Due to the ingrained and structural roots of social violence in Asia, emphasis on structural peacebuilding is crucial. The chapters also indicate that structural peacebuilding will be an uphill battle because it typically represents a "threat" to the status quo or the prevailing authoritarian regimes. However, for social justice to prevail, structural peacebuilding is imperative. Recognizing this importance, the first part of this closing chapter discusses peace psychology in Asia taking into account its geohistorical legacies, notably colonialism, collective culture, and religion. The second section elucidates the future directions of peace psychology in Asia along three themes, tradition vis a vis modernity, peacebuilding across social layers, and governance-related matters.

Peace Psychology or Peace Psychologies in Asia?

If there is to be an Asian peace psychology, what should be its nature and its relevance? What can we take to be the distinguishing mark of peace psychology of so vast a region, with so much diversity? Are there quintessential values that can be

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the bases of Asian peace psychology and somehow distinguish Asians from other people in the world, and can such distinctions apply to all parts of Asia's immensely large and heterogeneous population?

What we likewise need to realize is that Asian countries are in different stages of economic and sociopolitical developments that have bearings on the nature of the country's social conflicts and the practice of peace psychology. Three tiers of developmental transition can be discerned: (1) we have the most economically and technologically advanced countries that include Japan, South Korea, Singapore, Hong Kong, and Taiwan; (2) in the next tier, we have Mainland China, India, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, Pakistan, and the Philippines; and (3) in the least developed we have Vietnam, Cambodia, Myanmar, and those in central Asia. Thus, the nature of peace psychology in Asia will to a large extent reflect the concerns of the people at that particular juncture, and this can clearly be seen in the chapters of this volume.

According to Christie (2006), three themes can be discerned in post-Cold War peace psychology, and these are "... (1) greater sensitivity to geohistorical context, (2) a more differentiated perspective on the meanings and types of violence and peace, and (3) a systems view of the nature of violence and peace" (p. 3). These themes are even more evident in Asian countries due to their varied legacies (Montiel, this volume). The current volume is organized by regions (i.e., South Asia, East Asia, and Southeast Asia) because the nature of social conflicts and peace in Asia vary by regions. There also is variation within each specific country.

For example, South Asia as represented by India is defined by conflict about group relations and identities, with religion adding another layer to the conflict. The countries of East Asia made up of Japan, Taiwan, and China talk of forgiveness, collective memories, current intergroup relations, and psychological aspects of economic gaps. The chapters on Southeast Asia, in contrast, strongly resonate on the theme of reconciliation, particularly peacemaking and peacebuilding processes.

Examining each of the regions more closely, there are again differences in the nature of the conflicts. For example, while the chapter by Khan examines violence in Kashmir that started as a dispute between India and Pakistan, Khan and Sen look at communal tensions between Hindus and Muslims in India. In both chapters, identity (national, ethnic, and religious) is crucial, and it is this question of identity that lies at the root of much of the conflict and violence.

Thus, there are conflicts within the country (religious, ethnic, and identity issues) as well as between countries (India and Pakistan in the case of Kashmir) that will influence the discipline of peace psychology in India. Similarly within the other Asian regions, the same diversity in the nature of social conflicts and its narratives are observed. Adopting a systems approach, which views the nature of conflict and peace as rooted in geohistorical factors, may also provide a more holistic view as it suggests that the nature of conflict and peace and the preeminent issues of the time will vary across countries. Therefore, while it is indeed tempting to see peace

psychology in Asia as a monolithic practice applicable to all Asian countries, this clearly is not the case.

In addition, many of the social conflicts reported in these chapters are phrased in term of the “us–them” distinction (with “us” as good and “them” as evil), using the divisive markers of nation, identity, religion, race/ethnicity, or class. For example, Khan and Sen showed that while the causes of the Hindu–Muslim conflict in India are complex, identity politics is the main culprit with the two parties anchoring their identity within their own cultural groups and kept in place by those in power to sustain their political agenda. Religion, as the all-encompassing and exclusive identity that sets people apart from each other, is used as the dividing factor, akin to the way it was exploited during the time of the partition of the Indian subcontinent, reminding people of the painful memories of the Hindu–Muslim riots of the time.

To a large extent, the expression of social conflicts into the “us–them” distinction is due to the colonial past, perpetuated by the authoritarian regimes that replaced them.

Structural Violence and the Vestiges of Colonialism in Asia

Histories of Asian countries are marked by colonial occupations. These colonial powers dominated and exploited territories to enrich their motherlands. To ensure their continued domination and control, these colonial powers imposed certain structures that were meant to keep the locals in their place or pit them against one another to prevent uprisings against their rule. The British, for example, perfected and implemented the system of “divide and rule” in the countries under their control, favoring a particular group and neglecting the concerns of other groups.

After World War II, these colonies gained independence, but postwar regimes continued with the various forms of authoritarian state interventions not much different from that of their colonial masters. Why? The structures imposed during colonial rule had become too deeply entrenched in the society over the centuries and were the only viable governing system familiar to the people. In addition, those who held power realized that they could use the existing system to their advantage to ensure their grip on power.

Hence, during the nation’s formative years (and in some cases to the present), Asian countries were predominantly authoritarian in orientation, but claimed and practiced a few democratic forms borrowed from the West like elections, universal suffrage, and political parties. Today, Asian states tend to be typified by a government invested with the responsibility of upholding collective needs, but with entrenched political elites and an absence of many liberal democratic practices (Inoguchi & Newman, 1997). Malaysia, for example, has been ruled by the same multiethnic coalition party since independence in 1957. A similar longevity of power (party-based or family-based) is also seen in other Asian countries. In these countries, a strong government and a curtailment of some political rights are deemed necessary in the interests of the society. The leaders of these countries further

claimed that the multiethnic nature of their country (another legacy of colonialism) and the demands of managing the welfare of developing societies dictate certain priorities and an element of authoritarianism. In most cases, the judiciary and its enforcement agencies are subservient to the group in power, hence the potential for internal repression and state violence. Thus, many of the present conflicts observed in Asia are due to this legacy of the past where conflicts are rooted in structural inequalities with huge differences in political and economic power among the different groups, divisions that often are aggravated by religious differences.

Collectivist Values, Social Violence, and Peace in Asia

While traditions vary across Asia, there are some common characteristics. For example, it is often said that Asian societies are collectivist, based on a group orientation where the interests of the group are felt to come before those of the individual (Hofstede, 1980; Oyserman, Koon, & Kemmelmeier, 2002; Triandis, 1995). The consequence of this, it is argued, is that Asians are more group conscious than people in the West, who are seen as more individualistic; they work for the good of the group, are less selfish, and accept that cohesion and stability of the group are more important than the personal interests of individuals.

Group orientation is also associated with values such as self-effacement, selfdiscipline, and personal sacrifice to the greater good. This is integral to perceptions of public morality, harmony, and social dynamism. Respect for family ties and the elderly, frugality, filial piety, hard work, and teamwork are further elements of this matrix (Koh, 1993). These much-hyped characteristics have popularly been known as “Asian values.” This concept of “Asian values,” however, has serious methodological problems and limitations because it implies that all Asian countries share a value system that is identifiable and distinct, transcending national, religious, and ideological differences (Khong, 1997). In addition, the advocates of “Asian values” have tended to look primarily at East Asia (Korea, Japan, and China) and have ignored Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Central Asia.

Despite these constraints, Asian cultures are, on the whole, more collective than Western cultures, with a greater emphasis on group orientation and relationship (e.g., Hofstede, 1980; Norenzayan, Smith, Kim, & Nisbett, 2002). These collective values have been exploited and politicized by certain regimes in defense of their authoritarian governance. Hence, in many Asian countries, cultural values such as consensus and harmony are used as a tool to control dissent. As an example, in these societies, the Confucian tradition of acceptance of hierarchy, the need for social harmony, respect and reverence for family, and benevolence in government (Inoguchi & Newman, 1997) is used to justify the existing paternalistic social order. In other words, these values are used to consolidate the state’s authority in the interest of the “common good” and create a submissive population that is respectful of authority and hierarchy. Because of social historical forces, these values have

found expression as cultural norms today. But these collective values can equally be put to good use under the right leadership.

The Religious Factor in Asian Public Life

Religion is an integral component of Asian cultural values and one that has a profound effect on people's lives. This can be seen in both of the People Power movements in the Philippines where the Catholic Church was central in ousting Marcos and Estrada from office. The recent demonstrations of the monks in Myanmar against the ruling military Junta (September 2007) also has given the general public a boost in their struggle for democracy. Asia boasts a diversity of religions, chiefly Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Christianity, Taoism, and many others (Confucianism is not a religion, but its philosophy is practiced in many East Asian and Chinese societies in Southeast Asia). Despite the onslaught of globalization (and previously modernization), religion still plays a major role in the life of Asians and contributes to identity and group orientation.

The chapters in this volume attest to the importance of religion in Asian public life. While religion is seen as the cause of conflict and violence in the world, Noor and Moten (2007) argued that religion has been used as a convenient justification for other underlying problems, historically rooted in colonialism, accompanied by conflicts encouraged by the proxy wars of the Cold War era (Montiel, 2003), and for other contemporary failings in the social political landscape of these newly independent Asian countries (such as social injustices, poverty, unemployment, political repression, etc.). This view of religion as a cause of conflict and violence, however, gained impetus with the publication of Samuel Huntington's controversial thesis on the clash of civilizations, advanced in the post-Cold War context in international politics (1996). Such simplistic thinking on the role of religion as a source of conflict is clearly described by Muluk and Malik (this volume). While many perceived the violence in Maluku to be caused by religion, Muluk and Malik showed that the violence was in fact due to the long history of structural inequalities that were put in place during colonial times. This kind of massive violence cannot be explained simply by religion or ethnicity but needs a multilevel explanation that takes into account the historical, social, and intergroup levels. Because of such deep-rooted inequalities between the groups (further compounded by religion), minor disagreements or squabbles become sufficient triggers to provoke the groups into direct intergroup violence as in the case of Maluku. Often, religion is only a convenient reason to justify a conflict.

What is sometimes overlooked is that religion can be used as a tool in peacemaking and peacebuilding (Khisbiyah; Pohl; Noor; Muluk; this volume). Khisbiyah, for example, investigates media discourse on the issues of violence, social justice, and peacebuilding among three Indonesian Muslim chapters corresponding to conservative, moderate, and progressive groups and showed that their views on these issues are not monolithic and do not occur in a sociopolitical vacuum. She postulates that constructive dialogue and reconciliation among these highly contested diverse Muslim groups, as well as between Muslim and non-

Muslim groups, are possible. Similarly, Pohl demonstrates that Islamic educational institutions are agents in the network of civil Islam, promoting justice and peacebuilding and fostering values that are essential for peaceful coexistence in a plural society such as Indonesia. Noor's chapter suggests that similar religious values can be the common ground to initiate dialogue between Malays and Chinese. Muluk describes how religion, more specifically the Islamic principle of *Islah* (forgiveness), was used to reconcile the victims of the *Tanjung Priok* tragedy with their past perpetrators. These chapters emphasized that in Asian societies where religion plays a central role in public life, religion and religious education can be used to educate and improve civil society, particularly when the opportunities provided by the state are limited. However, while championing religious peacemaking and peacebuilding, it should be acknowledged that in most cases, on their own, they are never sufficient, and to be effective, they need to be used alongside other conventional approaches (Smock, 2006).

In sum, due to the varied nature of social conflicts experienced in the different Asian countries, it would be more appropriate to talk of peace psychologies, rather than peace psychology, in Asia.

Future Directions

There are three concerns that I would like to consider in this final section: first, achieving some balance between tradition and modernity; second, peacebuilding at the personal, relational, and structural levels; and third, deliberating on governance and peacebuilding.

Balancing Tradition and Modernity

Asia, as other parts of the world, cannot escape the process of globalization or the growing integration and interconnectedness of economies and societies around the world. How can globalization and its accompanying processes affect Asia, especially the practice of peace psychology in Asia? Fukuyama argued that globalization and its processes may lead to "... an increasing homogenization of all human societies, regardless of their historical origins or cultural inheritances" (Fukuyama, 1992, p. xiv). While this may be true to some extent, as observed in the dilution of cultural differences and the breakdown of traditional values and institutions, the reverse is equally possible. People may become even more aware of their cultures as a backlash to what are perceived as uncertainties in the sociopolitical landscape. This phenomenon can be seen in the revival of traditional values and/or a rediscovery of indigenous cultures as well as religion.

Indonesia and Malaysia have witnessed a mushrooming of Islamic movements that view themselves as counterforces to cultural domination by the global West

(Khisbiyah, this volume). While the goal of these groups is to assert their religious identity in the face of what they regard as imperializing ideas like modernization and secularism, many may also turn to radicalism, especially in circumstances where moderate ways are perceived to have taken too long to produce results. A similar process, a return to the local, what Hall (1991) calls “ethnicity” can also result as a counter-reaction to marginalization.

Liu and Sibley (this volume) provided another perspective on how a society can maintain continuity in the midst of change, that is, via historical narratives. Using the case of New Zealand, they showed that both Maoris and Pakeha accepted the Treaty of Waitangi as the most important historical event in its history. However, while all groups share this content, they differed in how they positioned this history in terms of contemporary relevance; that is, “... those opposed to historical redress position the past as irrelevant to the present, whereas those in favor of historical redress position the present as embedded in structures produced by past injustices” (Liu & Shibley, this volume, p. 21). Therefore, the way the group’s history is represented will specify what it was before, what it is now, and what it will be in the future. These social representations of history are important for the country’s political culture; as a society moves into a new era or faces new challenges, it may need to renew its social contract with its members and negotiate the past in light of the present and the future.

The chapter by Atsumi and Suwa on the historical conflict and reconciliation between Japan and China, however, found that the young in Japan do not see the present to be connected to the past. While they are aware of their country’s history, they somehow chose to be apolitical and more interested in current universal issues. In other words, they are more attuned to present global happenings, rather than the past historical conflict between Japan and China. To them, the past is the past, let bygones be bygones. Why should they, the young, be bound by the past of their parents or grandparents’ generation? Reminiscing on the past will not help them deal with changes that are currently taking place in their environment.

Asian societies are presently caught at such a crossroad between the traditional and the modern, where the old institutions and values are increasingly being brought in contact with modern forces. And, whether they like it or not, Asian societies will have to deal with this situation. As shown in the case of Japan, the young are indifferent to the history of the past. Thus, should they totally disconnect with the past and embrace only the present and the future? Or can the old values be revitalized in the context of the present? In other words, can they exploit the opportunities of the present environment, while at the same time retaining their cultural roots? And are they willing to do so? These are some questions that Asian societies must grapple with in light of changes brought by globalization.

Estuar and Montiel (this volume) show how Asians at this crossroad can exploit and make full use of modern technology as a tool for advocacy work in peace psychology by facilitating and promoting civic engagement and social movements. In the context of globalization forces, traditions and cultural identity can coexist with modernity. As shown in their chapter, the interaction between human agency and technology produces cognitive and behavioral changes, making people more

innovative, enabling them to overcome traditional restraint, and offering the opportunity to mobilize from the bottom up. This is very much needed in many Asian societies where the established political structures do not function as adequate avenues for the expression of grievances and aspirations, a problem that has also contributed to civic activism and changing expectations of authority and leadership. The study also provides an example of how tools developed for online socializing can be successfully co-opted to assist in times of crisis, providing up-to-the-minute information from many areas that traditional media may not be able to reach.

How Asian societies balance tradition with modernity must be contextualized within the country's social and cultural fabrics, and we cannot readily assume what works best in one society will also work in another. Some societies may refuse to open up to the new challenges, while others are increasingly embracing these changes. A few may even want to reinterpret history to justify their political agenda. Therefore, globalization will not result in a sweeping away of culture or a massive resurgence of traditional values, but rather we will see some elements of push and pull with the balance varying across societies. Such changes are to be found in all societies, but due to the mainly authoritarian nature of Asian societies, these changes have added an element of anxiety to the process of change. For example, after 32 years under Suharto's rule, Indonesians are still paying for the effects of his "New Order" legacy. While civic and social movements are stronger, corruption and poverty are still rampant with structural peace yet to be achieved.

Peacebuilding Across Social Layers: Individual, Group, and Society

There are three levels of peacebuilding that should be addressed in Asia: the individual (personal), group (relational), and society (structural). Most of the peacebuilding efforts in Asian countries are still situated at the individual and group levels. However, if the long-term goal of peace psychology is for fairness and justice to prevail in society, or peacebuilding as referred to by Christie and colleagues (2001), then increasingly the next course of action is to strive for structural peacebuilding.

Peacebuilding at the individual level centers on desired changes in the person. After a traumatic experience, individuals need to undergo some sort of healing process to enable them to move forward. Studies have shown that when ignored, some victims of past violence are at risk for becoming perpetrators of future violence (van der Merwe & Vienings, 2001). The *Tanjung Priok* tragedy shows how even after so many years, the psychological and emotional effects of the tragedy still haunt the victims, curtailing their role in society. Because the perpetrators were those in power, the victims were able to help themselves by initiating the process of reconciliation (with the help of a third party), only after the downfall of Suharto. Doing so gave the victims a sense of empowerment. At the same time, the perpetrators were relieved of their past wrongdoing and showed remorse by

compensating the victims for their past suffering (Muluk, this volume). Due to the central role of religion in Indonesia, the mediator or the third party was a respected religious actor, and the mediation process itself was carried out within a religious framework, providing an example of a successful faith-based intervention, accompanied by conventional diplomacy.

While counseling is helpful at the individual level, it may not be feasible due to stigmatization and apprehension about such practices in the Asian context. Awareness of the benefits of such sessions needs to be disseminated in casual or everyday interactions. In addition, health professionals and volunteers need to be familiar with the local language and context so that they can design programs that are meaningful to the people, drawing from traditional and communal practices and customs whenever possible. In the *Tanjung Priok* case, for example, many sessions were held between the perpetrators and the victims to clarify the perspectives of both sides. While these were not called “counseling” per se, they were similar to counseling sessions in that there were facilitators who moderated the sessions, asking individuals to talk and share their experiences, and in doing so bring into the open what they had kept for a long time. The cathartic effect for both parties was just as therapeutic as found in traditional counseling. Therefore, in this case, the “counseling” was contextualized within the language of the locals.

The next level of peacebuilding activities focuses on repairing damaged relationship between conflicting parties via communication and dialogue with the goal of reconciliation, forgiveness, and trust building. As shown by several chapters in the volume (Muluk; Muluk & Malik; Noor), dialogue between parties can increase their awareness of their own role in the conflict and develop a more accurate perception of their own and the other group’s identity. Such dialogue can lead to a deeper understanding and can help to change the image of the other. At this level, the goal of peacebuilding is to achieve some sort of a working relationship between the conflicting groups. A shared future vision with the groups working together in joint projects should be envisaged, if possible. Muluk shows that while reconciliation can pave the way for the past to be acknowledged and wrongdoings redressed, the groups somehow failed to envision a common, connected future. Indeed, this is not an easy task but repeated endorsements and outreach via a variety of mass communication tools (Internet, TV, radio, and print media) as well as educational and community activities such as peace-education projects, conflict-resolution training, and community-outreach projects can help the groups to see the possibility of working together for a shared future (Lund, 2001). At both the individual and group levels, in the societies where religion is still central, aspects of religious peacebuilding can be integrated into the local, traditional, or indigenous approach to make it more meaningful for the people.

The role of women in peacebuilding is often overlooked. While in armed conflict, women are often stereotypically portrayed as passive victims or recipients of relief aid, Batistiana (this volume) showed that women can also be combatants and peacebuilders, as reflected in the Moros of Mindanao. In their role as peacebuilders, these women are instrumental in NGO work, community organization, and economic empowerment, among others. In these relational roles, women, due to

their very nature of being caretakers of the family, are seen to be nurturant while at the same time are also protective and supportive and act as mediators between other individuals and groups.

The final level of peacebuilding is less often carried out but is equally important. This is the structural dimension or the root causes of the conflict: social conditions that foster violent conflict. As noted, in Asian countries, crises arise out of structural roots, laid down during colonial rule and perpetuated by the post-independence regimes that replaced them (Montiel, 2003; this volume). As stable peace must be built on social, economic, and political foundations that serve the needs of the people (Haugerudbraaten, 1998), these root causes, though complex, must be addressed.

To initiate social structural change is no easy task. Take the case of Malaysia for example (Noor, this volume); the affirmative action policies taken by the government after the race riots can be considered structural peacebuilding because they aimed to restructure the Malaysian society to make it more equitable and balanced. These policies are structural changes in the “economic” sphere, and they are integral in preventing future conflict. However, because structural changes in the “political” domain were not adequately addressed, problems remain to this day, including the lack of transparent and accountable elections, judicial and constitutional reforms, political parties, institutions that provide procedures, and mechanisms for effectively handling and resolving conflicts, among others. In fact, during this time the government amended several acts to make the political situation even more repressive (such as the Sedition Act and the Internal Security Act); the implementation of these economic policies soon became corrupted, benefiting the rich with political connections, rather than the targeted poor. Therefore, while the policies can be construed as structural peacebuilding efforts, because the basic structural foundations of the country have not changed much since colonial times, problems still occur. That is why even with the People Power movements in the Philippines, authoritarian rule remains. This is the dilemma that confronts many Asian countries; the institutional controls of a just government have not fully taken root.

While the goal of peacebuilding is to create sustainable peace characterized by the absence of physical and structural violence, the elimination of discrimination, and self-sustainability (Reychler, 2001) or in other words, social justice (Christie, Wagner & Winters, 2001; MacNair, 2002), moving toward this type of environment goes beyond mere problem solving or conflict management. There are, however, signs that show Asian countries are moving in this direction, as discussed in the next section on governance.

Structural Peacebuilding: Making Governance Structures Sensitive to Communal and Local Issues

To a large extent, peace psychology is also related to issues of governance, where violence and peace are concerns not only at the individual and group levels but more

importantly at the macro-structural level (Montiel, this volume). Because good governance is seen to address structural violence by its emphasis on positive development outcomes at the macro-structural level (such as reducing poverty, illiteracy, unemployment, social injustices, etc.), it is considered a vital peacebuilding project.

What does governance mean? According to Quibria (2006), governance is a broad, multidimensional concept that lacks operational precision depending on which aspect of governance is highlighted. If emphasis is on political regimes, then democracy, human rights, participation, and freedom of the press are some of the critical elements of governance. However, if economic management is stressed, sound economic management, requiring the support of an efficient bureaucracy, should be grounded in a transparent, participatory, and accountable decision-making process. Or, if economic policy is emphasized, governance is reflected in the capacity of the government to design, formulate, and implement appropriate policies, taking into account the needs of the country. But when governance is used to define the legal and judicial frameworks, this highlights the separation, independence, and effectiveness of the judiciary; the enforcement of contracts; and the rule of law. Therefore, governance is often used as an umbrella concept to refer to a range of different, albeit related, ideas.

With respect to Asian countries, how should governance be defined? By right, it should encompass all the above-related aspects, but Quibria's (2006) study exploring the relationship between governance and economic growth in Asia's developing economies seems to suggest that in these countries, not all aspects of governance are equally critical. What is important depends on the developmental stage of the country. In governance-deficit countries (e.g., China, Cambodia, Indonesia, Thailand, Vietnam, to name a few) compared to those exhibiting a surplus (e.g., Hong Kong, Singapore, India, Malaysia, to name a few), the economic aspects of governance relating to government effectiveness and regulatory quality are regarded as more important than political aspects relating to voice and accountability or control of corruption. In other words, in the former countries, political liberalization is secondary to basic economic well-being. What this implies is that there may be a progression in terms of how governance is to be viewed. While both are equally important (as economic reforms are dependent on the politics of the country), in the Asian context, maybe issues of governance should be taken one step at a time, to enable change to have time to make an impact. In this case, governance can be seen as a gradual process from growth and economic development to social transformation and, hopefully, to political change. Therefore, from the perspective of social justice, the responsibility of grassroots peacebuilding is to ensure that economic and political development takes place in an equitable way.

However, in many cases when governance is referred to, it is the political aspects that are emphasized, because to a large extent, economic and social outcomes are dependent on the country's political regimes. Asia, in particular, is still characterized by a strong bureaucracy and an absence of the separation of powers. In fact, the state, the ruling party, and bureaucracy are seen as one and the same. The principles of a just government such as justice, accountability, and transparency with public

trust as the glue that holds the community together is not properly implemented (Hunter, 2008). The institutions that are supposed to assure a stable collective life are usually corrupted; they have allowed themselves to become the personal tools of the ruling party and not of the public. Currently, in many Asian countries, the old restraints on power and greed are gradually fading, yet the institutional controls of good governance have not fully taken root; this transitional limbo has resulted in a system of governance that is mostly based on money and coercive power. The changes brought by globalization have stimulated an intensification of demands for participatory politics at the community level. That is why the younger, more educated, and aware populace are especially up in arms; the times are telling them that if they are to continue being governed in this manner, their future survival in the modern world will be compromised.

Increasingly, governmental authority is questioned and accountability is demanded by the governed. Exposed to modern challenges, many Asians look for a government that is more responsive to their immediate economic and local needs (such as proper schools and hospitals), rather than for more political rights as in the West (Khong, 1997). In most cases, Asians are open to change, but they seek to make change relevant to their personal circumstances. In doing so, they look for a government that is accountable at the local level. This is a politics of local identity that promotes local interaction and, in doing so, encourages participation from the grassroots.

This politics of identity can be seen in Taiwan, where repressed feelings of a distinct Taiwanese identity now find political expression, and the independence versus reunification debate is increasingly being brought into the open (Huang, this volume). A vigorous grassroots politics is also seen in Indonesia through the *Tanjung Priok* incident and the *Baku Bae* Movement (Muluk; Muluk & Malik; this volume), where locals get their acts together to reconcile and put a closure to the tragedies that have caused them so much grief for so long. Similarly in the Philippines and Malaysia, grassroots politics and concerns with local issues are increasingly being brought to the fore.

We are witnessing an emergence of a new Asian politics and government that have as the foundation, concerns of the community, rather than some abstract elitist notions. The gradual process is already taking place. For example, the recent 12th general election in Malaysia on March 8, 2008, rung a death knell for old-style Malaysian politics and introduced a new multiethnic politics, where people voted across the racial divide, voting as Malaysians, not as Malays, Chinese, or Indians (Noor, this volume). They indicated that they wanted a fair, just, and equal society based on merits, no longer on ethnicity or religion.

The recent emergence in Malaysia of a nonracial politics is made possible due to a number of factors, among others the populace's unhappiness with the present ruling party that has been in power since independence in 1957. Being in power without a strong opposition for so long turned the long-time ruling party into an elective dictatorship. The abuse of power was blatant, as in cases where policies that were suppose to benefit the poor were only benefiting the rich with political connections and a judiciary that was increasingly being seen as an extension of the

ruling party. A more educated populace with greater awareness of global happenings has also helped. Prior to the election, the information and communication technology (ICT) was used by the opposition to reach and inform the public similar to the way described by Estuar and Montiel (this volume), as a tool for advocacy work to aid and promote civic engagement and social movement because the state machinery was seen as the mouthpiece of the ruling party and could no longer be trusted to give a fair and balanced report.

Though the National Front still won, their majority was substantially reduced, and with a stronger opposition in parliament, they would now have to be more transparent and accountable for their acts. This change also implies that the old guards have to reassess themselves and make radical changes if they want to remain relevant. They need to accept that the political landscape has changed and the policies they make affect people of all races. Therefore, the old policies based on “defending Malay rights” no longer sells, and policy debates must promote policy issues such as the rights of Malaysians and on matters such as improving the school systems and hospitals, and the recent price hikes in basic goods, rather than sentiments.

Changes in governance must involve structural changes that are informed by the people, because those in power have too much to lose to risk making changes. Based on the chapters of this volume, there are two challenges to the change narrative from authoritarian to more democratic practices. First is that change must be pluralized to involve multiple confrontations involving domination and resistance rather than a simple mode-of-production narrative. This is similar to the multilevel model of peacebuilding posited by Christie et al. (2008), where there are multiple entry points, representing multiple opportunities available in the peacebuilding efforts. Second, people’s basic needs and the existing structure of power relations need to be questioned and addressed.

Will new systems of government be any better than the one that they replace? While it will be informed by more democratic practices, the precise mechanism is still to be decided and will most probably be based on local needs by giving people a voice in the decisions that shape their lives. Due to differences in the sociohistorical backgrounds of the countries, there is bound to be country specificity with regard to the appropriate governance practice. As mentioned by Dixit (2004, p. 4), “... it is not always necessary to create replicas of Western-style (governance) from scratch, it may be possible to work with such alternative institutions as are available, and build on them.” Hence, some amount of experimentation on existing governance structures may be needed to make it more sensitive to local needs. Thus, as there is no one Asian culture, there cannot be one Asian government structure that fits all. However, on the basis of what we are seeing, it will be one that relates to grassroots politics and is concerned with local issues.

Conclusion

Based on the chapters in this volume, if we are to pigeonhole the kinds of social conflicts in Asia within the 2×2 systems perspective of peace psychology (Christie, Wagner, & Winter, 2001), we would see a disproportionate representation of structural violence related to colonialism and authoritarian regimes, identity (ethnic/race, religious, national), and poverty (very similar to those reported earlier by Montiel, 2003). With respect to peacebuilding, however, the reverse is observed, where examples of direct peace are more prevalent than structural peace. While this discrepancy between the kinds of violence and peace can be handled most effectively at the government level, as mentioned, those in power would be the least likely to do so. Thus, change must be initiated by the grassroots, and we see this gradually happening in many Asian countries. In doing so, the issue is how to redress social-historical injustices without alienating any one particular group (based on their many different identities) and build a tolerant “cosmopolitan” society where cosmopolitanism, according to Appiah (2006), comprises three distinct elements: people have obligations to others, differences are important and tolerance is necessary for mutual coexistence, and acceptance of both universal and local values. While Lindner (this volume) describes the promise of having “unity in diversity” and dignity throughout Asia, in many cases, it is the “clash of civilizations” that is manifest. This is indeed a challenge for peace psychologists in Asia, to negotiate a respect for differences that are rooted in varying geohistorical contexts.

It follows then, the term “Asian peace psychology” does not hold much meaning beyond the geographical one. The diversity of the region – ethnic/racial, cultural, religious, and historical – makes it one of the most fascinating areas of the world, but also seriously complicates the task of defining a discrete “Asian” form of peace psychology. Furthermore, as witnessed by the chapters in this volume, not only are the kinds of conflicts diverse in the different parts of Asia depending on the developmental stage of the country and geohistorical conditions, the kinds of peacebuilding approaches also must be sensitive and unique to the country. While some principles from the Western peace psychology literature may be applicable to the Asian case, Montiel (this volume) stresses that these may need to be contextualized in the language and culture of the locals to be meaningful. In many cases, due to Asia’s strong collective culture, peace psychology in Asia will need to look beyond individual psychology phenomena and consider the larger shared units. Peace psychology in Asia also will be defined by a great diversity of issues and approaches that allow for the past to be remembered and the future incorporating narratives that have yet to be defined. In short, while some peacebuilding approaches may share similarities with the West, others may be distinctly Asian.

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